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AI



Meta names Shengjia Zhao as chief scientist of AI superintelligence unit



Maxwell Zeff — 1:58 PM PDT · July 25, 2025

Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg announced Friday that former OpenAI researcher Shengjia Zhao will lead research efforts at the company's new AI unit, Meta Superintelligence Labs (MSL). Zhao contributed to several of OpenAI's largest breakthroughs, including ChatGPT, GPT-4, and the company's first AI reasoning model, o1.

"I'm excited to share that Shengjia Zhao will be the Chief Scientist of Meta Superintelligence Labs," Zuckerberg said in a [post on Threads](#) Friday.

"Shengjia co-founded the new lab and has been our lead scientist from day one. Now that our recruiting is going well and our team is coming together, we have decided to formalize his leadership role."

IMAGE CREDITS:

Zhao will set a research agenda for MSL under the leadership of Alexandr Wang, the former CEO of Scale AI who was [recently hired to lead the new unit](#).

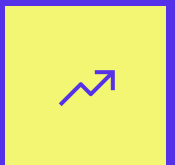
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Alexandr Wang  
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We are excited to announce that [@shengjia_zhao](#) will be the Chief Scientist of Meta Superintelligence Labs!

Shengjia is a brilliant scientist who most recently pioneered a new scaling paradigm in his research. He will lead our scientific direction for our team.

Let's go 🚀



7:57 PM · Jul 25, 2025



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Wang, who does not have a research background, was viewed as a somewhat unconventional choice to lead an AI lab. The addition of Zhao, who is a reputable research leader known for developing frontier AI models, rounds out the leadership team. To further fill out the unit, Meta has hired several high-level researchers from OpenAI, Google DeepMind, Safe Superintelligence, Apple, and Anthropic, as well as pulling researchers from Meta's existing Fundamental AI Research (FAIR) lab and generative AI unit.

Zuckerberg notes in his post that Zhao has pioneered several breakthroughs, including a “new scaling paradigm.” The Meta CEO is likely referencing Zhao’s work on OpenAI’s reasoning model, o1, in which he is listed as a foundational contributor alongside OpenAI co-founder Ilya Sutskever. Meta currently doesn’t offer a competitor to o1, so AI reasoning models are a key area of focus for MSL.

The Information reported in June that [Zhao would be joining Meta Superintelligence Labs](#), alongside three other influential OpenAI researchers — Jiahui Yu, Shuchao Bi, and Hongyu Ren. Meta has also recruited [Trapit Bansal](#), another OpenAI researcher who worked on AI reasoning models with Zhao, as well as three employees from OpenAI’s Zurich office who worked on multimodality.

Zuckerberg has gone to great lengths to set MSL up for success. The Meta CEO has been on a recruiting spree to staff up his AI superintelligence lab, which has entailed sending personal emails to researchers and inviting prospects to his Lake Tahoe estate. Meta has reportedly offered some researchers eight- and nine-figure compensation packages, [some of which are “exploding offers”](#) that expire in a matter of days.

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Meta has also upped its investment in cloud computing infrastructure, which should help MSL conduct the massive training runs required to create competitive frontier AI models.

By 2026, Zhao and MSL's researchers should have access to [Meta's 1 gigawatt cloud computing cluster, Prometheus](#), located in Ohio. Once online, Meta will be one of the first technology companies with an AI training cluster of Prometheus' size — 1 gigawatt is enough energy to power more than 750,000 homes. That should help Meta conduct the massive training runs required to create frontier AI models.

With the addition of Zhao, Meta now has two chief AI scientists, including Yann LeCun, the leader of Meta's FAIR lab. Unlike MSL, FAIR is designed to focus on long-term AI research — techniques that may be used five to 10 years from now. How exactly Meta's three AI units will work together remains to be seen.

Nevertheless, Meta now seems to have a formidable AI leadership team to compete with OpenAI and Google.

Topics: [AI](#) [AI talent wars](#) [Meta](#) [OpenAI](#)





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OpenAI spokesperson Kayla Wood confirmed to TechCrunch that Bansal had departed OpenAI. Bansal's [LinkedIn page](#) says that he left OpenAI in June.

Bansal has worked at OpenAI since 2022 and was a key player in kickstarting the company's work on reinforcement learning alongside co-founder Ilya Sutskever. He is listed as a foundational contributor on OpenAI's first AI reasoning model, o1.

Bansal could offer a significant lift to Meta's AI superintelligence lab, which also features leaders such as former [Scale AI CEO Alexandr Wang](#) and is [looking to add](#) former GitHub CEO Nat Friedman and Safe Superintelligence co-founder Daniel Gross. Bansal could help Meta develop a frontier AI reasoning model that's competitive with industry-leading technology, such as OpenAI's o3 or DeepSeek's R1. Currently, Meta does not offer an AI reasoning model publicly.

In recent months, Mark Zuckerberg has been on a hiring spree to build out Meta's new AI team, [offering \\$100 million compensation packages](#) to top researchers who join his company. It's unclear what Bansal was offered to join in this deal.

Nevertheless, it seems that Zuckerberg has been successful at nabbing top AI research talent.

Three other former OpenAI researchers — Lucas Beyer, Alexander Kolesnikov, and Xiaohua Zhai — have also joined Meta's AI superintelligence team in recent weeks, [The Wall Street Journal](#) reported on Wednesday. Bansal will join them, alongside former Google DeepMind researcher Jack Rae and former machine learning leader at the startup Sesame, Johan Schalkwyk, according to [Bloomberg](#).

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To further fill out its new AI unit, Zuckerberg reportedly tried to [acquire startups with heavy-hitting AI research labs](#), such as Sutskever's Safe Superintelligence, Mira Murati's [Thinking Machines Labs, and Perplexity](#). However, those talks never progressed to a final stage.

On a recent podcast, OpenAI CEO Sam Altman said Meta has been trying to poach his startup's top talent, but claimed that "[none of our best people](#) have decided to take him up on that."

A Meta spokesperson declined to comment.

AI reasoning models present a key area for Meta's AI superintelligence team to get right. In the last year, OpenAI, Google, and DeepSeek have shipped highly performant AI reasoning models that have pushed the limits of what software can do. By training AI models to work through problems before giving an answer, using additional time and computing resources to do so, AI labs have found

success in improving AI's performance on benchmarks and real-world tasks.

Meta's AI superintelligence lab could become a key internal group that powers products throughout the company, much like Google's DeepMind unit. Meta has an ambitious effort to [build AI agents for business](#) under the former Salesforce CEO of AI, Clara Shih. In order to build competitive agents, Meta needs to develop frontier AI reasoning models to power them.

With the addition of Bansal and other key AI researchers, Meta hopes to pull ahead in the AI race. That may be difficult given that [OpenAI plans to release an open AI reasoning model](#) in the coming weeks — an offering that could add even more pressure on Meta's open AI offerings.

This story was updated after publication with more details.

Topics: [AI](#) [Meta](#) [OpenAI](#)



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Ilya Sutskever will lead Safe Superintelligence following his CEO's exit

Maxwell Zeff — 10:29 AM PDT · July 3, 2025

OpenAI co-founder Ilya Sutskever says he is stepping into the CEO role at [Safe Superintelligence](#), the AI startup he launched in 2024. In a post on X, Sutskever confirmed Thursday that Daniel Gross, the startup's co-founder and CEO, departed the company as of June 29. Safe Superintelligence co-founder Daniel Levy is becoming president of the startup, according to Sutskever.

The announcement follows weeks of reporting that [Meta CEO Mark Zuckerberg was in advanced talks to hire Gross](#), as well as his longtime investing partner, former GitHub CEO Nat Friedman. At one point, Zuckerberg reportedly attempted to acquire all of Safe Superintelligence, a startup most recently valued at \$32 billion. Sutskever addressed those reports as well.

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“You might have heard rumors of companies looking to acquire us. We are flattered by their attention but are focused on seeing our work through,” said Sutskever. “We have the compute, we have the team, and we know what to do. Together we will keep building safe superintelligence.”

I sent the following message to our team and investors:

—

As you know, Daniel Gross’s time with us has been winding down, and as of June 29 he is officially no longer a part of SSI. We are grateful for his early contributions to the company and wish him well in his next...

— Ilya Sutskever (@ilyasut) [July 3, 2025](#)

Naturally, Gross’ departure may raise questions around the startup. If Safe Superintelligence was close to its goal — surely a groundbreaking technology, as it’s described — why would its co-founder leave to start something new, seemingly at Meta?

Notably, Safe Superintelligence describes itself as the world’s “first straight-shot SSI lab,” meaning the company has no other products or ambitions outside of developing, well, safe superintelligence. That’s the name, that’s the product, that’s its whole thing. Sutskever started Safe Superintelligence shortly after leaving OpenAI, where he played a role in the brief ousting of CEO Sam Altman.

Meanwhile, it seems likely that Meta Superintelligence Labs will develop technology that powers lots of the company’s products. In [Zuckerberg’s memo](#) announcing the new unit, he referenced Meta’s expertise in building and

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Aisha Malik - 14 hours ago

growing products that reach billions of people, and cited the early wins Meta has had in AI wearables.

That means Gross, who previously led AI teams at Apple after the iPhone maker acquired his startup, could have a more familiar role at Meta, should he join. Zuckerberg has also nabbed some [top researchers from OpenAI](#) and Google DeepMind to fill out his new AI team.

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Nevertheless, Sutskever may have his hands full as Safe Superintelligence's CEO. While he's held previous high-ranking positions, such as OpenAI's chief scientist, the CEO role may come with new challenges — such as raising new capital from investors and recruiting top talent. Sutskever notes in his post that he'll continue to oversee Safe Superintelligence's technical team.

Topics: [AI](#) [Ilya Sutskever](#) [OpenAI](#)

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